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Manmohan is slowly becoming a figure of ridicule for the Opposition, with L.K. Advani having called him the weakest prime minister ever. The party machinery has gone into an overdrive to portray this not as a surrender but as a way out of the impasse. The attempt to bail him out seems to have Sonia's tacit approval. Even the media-shy Patel has said that "the issue will be resolved through a dialogue with the Left on October 22" at an election rally in Vadodara. The PMO is worried, however, that having scented victory, the Left will now step up its pressure on economic reforms. "The only choice is between a lame duck and a dead duck government," says a Cabinet minister.

Elsewhere in the Capital, though, it is celebration time. Most office bearers at the CPI(M) headquarters were on va-

cation this week. It was not clear if AKG Bhavan was celebrating Dussehra, Manmohan's surrender or Karat's anti-imperialist victory. Apart from a couple of security guards and a front office manager, the only other person who was working through the undeclared holidays was the 59-year-old party general secretary. He had watched Manmohan and Sonia on TV as they paraded their lack of confidence, sacrificing the Government for the sake of the treaty. Within 48 hours of the remarks, the most powerful apparatchik in the country read in the papers about how the prime minister had admitted to "internal difficulties" in signing the India-specific safeguards agreement with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) when he had telephoned US President George Bush from Nigeria early this week.

Since the Left expects a formal response from the Government only on October 22, Karat's initial reaction was guarded. But he could not resist smiling at Manmohan's plight. After all, a score had to be settled. The prime minister had dared the Left to withdraw support from the UPA Government if it had a problem with the treaty. "Anyone can say anything in newspaper interviews. Our response to the situation did not come from who said what in the newspapers," Karat

told INDIA TODAY on October 17, when asked if Manmohan's statement had fractured the Left's working relationship with the Congress. His counterparts in CPI, RSP and the Forward Bloc had spoken out against what they had described as Manmohan's "provocation".

Karat chooses his words with caution. He enjoys the benefits of cold aggression.

The Left campaign had taken off on August 3, when its MPs began to demand an explanation from the Government on the Indo-US joint declaration of July 18. The monsoon session had already turned hostile for the Congress, with BJP and the Left on the same side of the divide. Matters worsened for the ruling coalition on August 8, when the prime min-

THE LAST LAUGH: Karat; the UPA-Left panel (left)



"US President George Bush is not popular in his own country, with only 30 per cent supporting him. So why should we dance to his tunes?"

trying to turn the defeat into a strategic pause. "The deal is not dead. It can be revived anytime. After all, China took 13 years to sign its deal," says a Congress minister. Meanwhile, Congressmen are wondering if Manmohan will play his resignation card again. Party spokesman Shakeel Ahmad has already issued a denial to quell speculations that the prime minister was considering giving up the top job hours after he boarded the flight to Nigeria. "The prime minister is as competent and as much in control as he was the day he took over," said Ahmad. There is no denying that